

The only exception, the Chinnaswamy Stadium in Bengaluru, is notorious for being a ground that heavily favours chasing sides. [See Fig. 3]

The other three venues also show an interesting pattern in scoring. All three have had an increase in the average first-innings score, but the average winning first-innings score has remained stable (no matches were won batting first in Vadodara in 2025, but the corresponding number in 2026 is well above the overall average, as expected). [See Fig. 4]

This perhaps indicates that teams become savvier to conditions and are able to approach setting a total with a more concrete idea of what a winning score would be. This explains why the average winning first-innings score remains relatively steady in comparison to the average score, which has risen sharply.

Familiarity with venues thus appears to take away some of the advantage that comes with chasing. Or perhaps chasing is a more pragmatic approach in new conditions.

Implications for future growth

With the women's game at an inflection point after India's ODI World Cup victory, there is an expectation that the WPL will grow too. Speaking to *Sportstar*, BCCI secretary Devajit Saikia indicated that the league's expansion was in the plan, saying, "In the coming times, when the number of teams in WPL also increases, the number of venues will also certainly be increased."

Stadiums like DY Patil, Bengaluru, and Vadodara have also developed a strong regular fan following. As the tournament expands, it remains to be seen whether the BCCI will look to bring the WPL back to these venues or move into new areas. Whether it chooses to do so could have an impact on team strategy, possibly emboldening more teams to follow Gardner and Co.'s approach of backing themselves to set a target.

Fig. 1: Decisions at the toss in WPL

There has been a clear shift towards captains opting to chase first in WPL from Period 1 (the 2023 and 2024 seasons) to Period 2 (2025 and 2026 seasons).

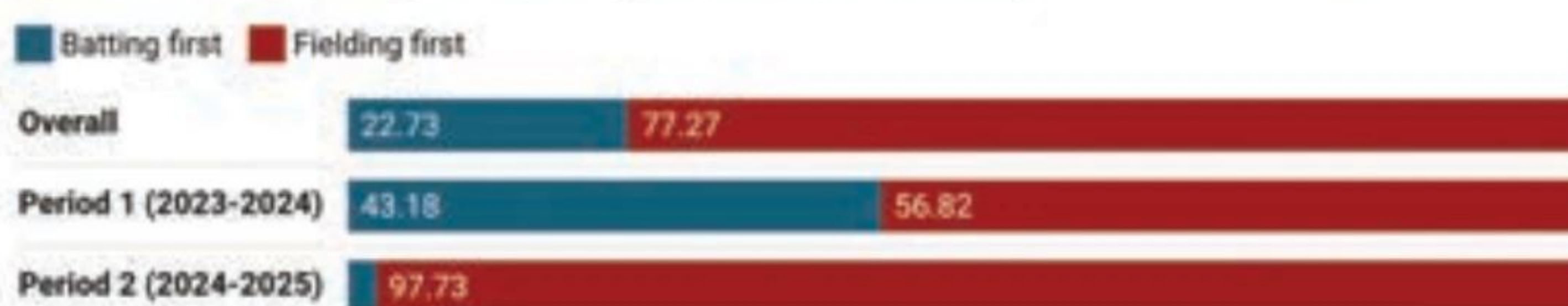


Fig. 2: Results by batting innings in WPL

The split of results by whether a team has batted first or bowled first has remained relatively consistent through Period 1 (2023 and 2024 seasons) and Period 2 (2025 and 2026 seasons).

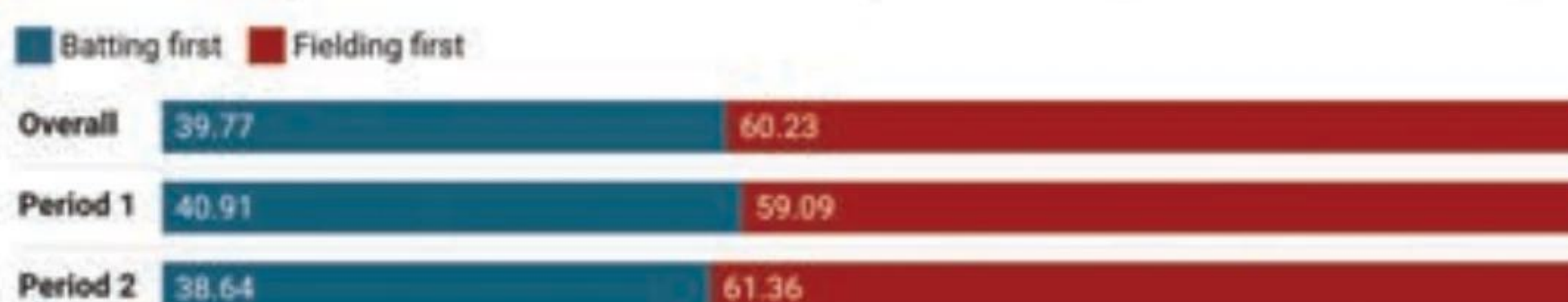


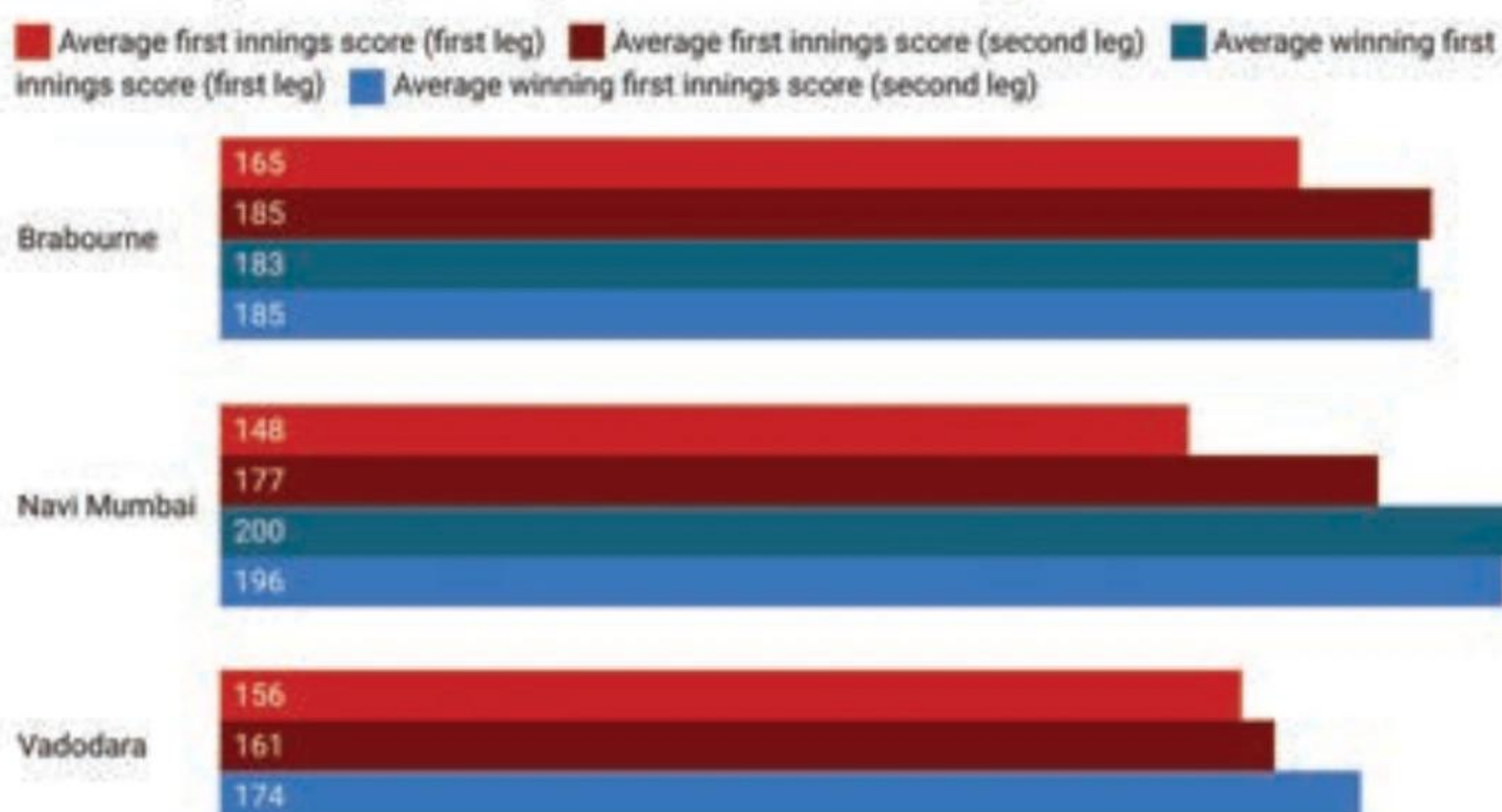
Fig. 3: Change in proportion of matches won by chasing

Bengaluru (2024 and 2025) is the only ground to show an increase in the proportion of matches won by chasing from the first leg held at the venue to the second. Brabourne (2023 and 2025), Navi Mumbai (2023 and 2026), and Vadodara (2025 and 2026) all show an opposite trend.



Fig. 4: Average first-innings score and winning first-innings scores by venue across legs

The average first-innings scores from first leg to second leg at these venues have all increased, but the average winning first-innings scores have remained fairly similar.



No team won batting first during the first WPL leg in Vadodara.